

The Internet of Things

The internet allows people to access data from millions of sources. The Internet of Things (IoT) is similar, but it connects devices instead of people.

What are the “things”?

To be part of the IoT, a device needs a sensor that collects data. It must also be able to communicate this data through Wi-Fi, Bluetooth, or phone networks. Not every smart device is part of the IoT. A Bluetooth speaker connects to devices but doesn't collect data. A fitness tracker may count your steps, but you can choose how that data is shared.

▽ Collecting and connecting

More and more gadgets are getting smart makeovers. Smartphones have a variety of sensors from accelerometers to Global Positioning System (GPS) units. Self-learning thermostats use motion sensors to know when to switch on. It won't be long until refrigerators are able to work out what they have inside, and whether it's fresh or not.

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Why have IoT?

The logic behind the IoT is that more data means better decisions. Better decisions equal less work, which equals more free time. In a nutshell, increased connectivity is used to automate tasks. Imagine a bracelet that monitors your sleeping patterns and turns on the coffee maker when you awake, or a lock that can be activated from a phone when someone leaves the house. Both these devices exist and can be configured for even more options.

